



# Grasping Straws?

*an original deck of lateral-thinking prompts — print-and-play edition*

1. Print pages 2–15 single-sided on the heaviest stock your printer accepts.
2. Optional backs: put the printed sheets back in and print the last page on the reverse of each (long-edge flip).
3. Cut along the lines. A ruler and a blade beat scissors.
4. Shuffle. The five rules cards are ways to play; the deck doesn't negotiate.

This free edition is for your own studio. The manufactured deck — real card stock, shuffled by your own hands — is the instrument; the site at [grasping-straws](http://grasping-straws) has the details. Card texts © the deck's author.



## Grasping Straws?

*an original deck of lateral-thinking prompts*

Solve the wrong  
problem beautifully.

Remove the part  
you rehearsed.

Do the last step first.

Halve it. Then  
halve the half.

Make the transition  
the destination.

Let the accident audition.

Give the mistake  
a name and a job.

Which rule are you  
obeying without  
being asked?

Trade your best idea  
for your strangest one.

Work at the speed  
of boredom.

Copy the structure;  
betray the content.

End earlier than feels safe.

Abandon symmetry  
mid-gesture.

Describe it to someone  
who cannot see it.  
Build what you said.

Make it hospitable  
to strangers.

What would this be at  
four in the morning?

Finish it badly, then  
defend the flaw.

Ask the least qualified  
person in the room.  
That may be you.

Tune to the room,  
not the chart.

Play the chord  
you can't name.

Voice it in two notes.

Detune one string;  
keep the fingering.

Let the drums lie  
about the tempo.

The overtone  
is the melody.

Treat the amp as  
the instrument.

Record the rehearsal.  
Discard the take.

What is the silence doing?



Turn one element to zero.  
Notice what remains.

Hold the shot  
until it confesses.

Weather is a  
character. Cast it.

Cut on the breath,  
not the action.

Let the location  
rewrite the scene.

Show the aftermath;  
imply the event.

Water, smoke, or dust:  
choose one witness.

Light it for the  
room it used to be.

The frame is a door.  
Which way does it open?

Write the footnote first.

Steal the syntax of a prayer.

Say it once. Trust the echo.

Translate it into plain  
speech; keep the ghost.

Delete every sentence  
you're proud of.  
Read what's left.

Let a minor  
character narrate.

The obstacle is  
the initiation.

Descend, retrieve, return.  
You are on the wrong step.

Read it as a cipher  
for something kind.

What would the older  
tradition call this?

Consult the dream,  
then disobey it.

Cross the threshold  
facing backward.

TEN MINUTES

*solo*

Draw one card. Obey it — literally,  
not approximately — for ten minutes.  
No second draw. Keep the result or  
throw it away, but look at it first.

THREE STRAWS

*solo*

Deal three cards face down. Turn  
them in order: what is actually  
wrong; how to work on it; when  
to stop. Write the third one down.

FIRST & LAST

*solo · one session*

Draw before you begin and work  
under the card. When you believe  
you're done, draw exactly one  
more and let it edit the ending.

### BLIND JURY

*3 or more*

One card for everyone, read aloud.  
No one says how they read it. Twenty  
minutes of work, then show the results  
side by side. Steal the best direction.

### EXQUISITE RELAY

*2 · over days or weeks*

One piece, passed back and forth.  
Each pass begins with a secret draw.  
When the piece is finished, reveal the  
cards in order and title it with one.



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